CONNECT DAILY

Monday 19 October 2026
themapsproject.com

A daily scan of national and South Yorkshire developments in education policy, inclusion, SEND, behaviour and accountability — weighted to primary and evidence sources, with links and a clear "so what for your school" line on the items that matter.

Useful? Forward it to a colleague. To join the circulation or partner with the network, get in touch.

TOP LINE

- A quiet national day - today's one firm development is procedural: the 2026-27 teacher Pay Order was laid in Parliament on 16 October, starting a 21-day 'praying period' that runs to 6 November before arrears can follow.
- Locally, Sheffield City Council's finance and performance committee votes today on £602k of government funding for a Firth Park Academy expansion adding three SEND rooms and 30 extra Year 7 places, alongside a temporary Parkwood Academy expansion.

→ **For your school:** *Worth a line to SLT if either school is a feeder or partner.*

- A reminder: Sheffield schools break for autumn half term next week (26-30 October).

DATES FOR THE DIARY

19 Oct 2026 — Sheffield City Council finance and performance committee votes on £602k funding for the Firth Park Academy SEND-places expansion.

26-30 Oct 2026 — Sheffield schools' autumn half term.

6 Nov 2026 — 21-day parliamentary 'praying period' ends for the 2026-27 teacher Pay Order.

SHEFFIELD & SOUTH YORKSHIRE

▪ **Firth Park and Parkwood set for expansion.** Sheffield's finance and performance committee meets today to approve passing £602,000 of government funding to Lift Schools, part of a £701,312 scheme giving Firth Park Academy three SEND rooms, refurbished creative-arts space and upgraded science labs - raising its admission number from 240 to 270. A temporary expansion at Parkwood Academy is bundled into the same paper, both aimed at a projected Year 7 places shortfall in 2027/28 and 2028/29. (The Star)

PAY & FUNDING

▪ **Pay Order laid, praying period now running.** The STPCD 2026-27 Teachers' Pay Order was laid in Parliament on 16 October, confirming the 3.5% uplift (5% at the bottom of the unqualified range), backdated to 1 September. MPs now have a 21-day 'praying period' to raise objections, ending 6 November - in practice this has never been exercised, so arrears should follow once it lapses. (Local Government Association)

JARGON-BUSTER · PRAYING PERIOD

Cropping up in today's pay story:

The 21 sitting days after a statutory instrument (like the Teachers' Pay Order) is laid in Parliament, during which an MP can table a motion against it. Rarely used, but it's why pay orders aren't final the day they're laid.

MAPS IN PRACTICE – TOOL SPOTLIGHT: SCHOOL+

A strong inclusion strategy is only as good as the cohort picture beneath it.

School+ is the MAPs cohort-vulnerability framework — it maps who your at-risk pupils are and why, giving your inclusion strategy an evidence base rather than a wish list. Explore School+

SOURCES MONITORED

Weighted official- and evidence-first. X is monitored for early signals from official accounts and named commentators, and corroborated against a primary source before anything is included.

Source	Type	What we track
OFFICIAL & STATUTORY		
DfE / GOV.UK	Government	Policy, funding, statutory guidance and statistics
Ofsted	Government	Inspection framework, report cards, annual report
Explore Education Statistics	Government data	Exclusions, suspensions, attendance, census data
House of Commons Library	Parliament	Neutral briefings on bills and policy
RESEARCH & EVIDENCE		
Education Endowment Foundation	Research	Evidence-based guidance, incl. inclusive teaching
NFER	Research	Assessment, workforce, disadvantage
Education Policy Institute	Think tank	Policy analysis and the disadvantage gap
Institute for Fiscal Studies	Think tank	School funding and spending analysis
FFT Education Datalab	Data analysis	Data-driven analysis of attainment and exclusions
INCLUSION & PREVENTION SPECIALISTS		
The Difference	Charity	Whole-school inclusion; "Who's Losing Learning?"
IPPR	Think tank	Lost learning, exclusions, SEND reform
Youth Endowment Fund	Research	What works to prevent youth violence & exclusion
Centre for Social Justice	Think tank	Exclusion tracker and social-mobility policy
Whole School SEND	Network	SEND practice, resources and reviews
SECTOR PRESS & COMMENTARY		
Schools Week	Press	Breaking sector news and investigations
Tes	Press	Practice, policy and workforce
The Guardian (Education)	Press	National coverage and comment
X (monitored)	Social	DfE, Ofsted, EEF and named voices — corroborated before use
LOCAL & REGIONAL		
The Star (Sheffield)	Local press	Local schools and Ofsted outcomes
Sheffield City Council	Local government	Council decisions, funding and local strategy
South Yorkshire MCA & Careers Hub	Regional	Regional skills, careers and funding

Connect Daily is part of Sheffield Connect. Compiled by Andy Marsden, Sector Inclusion Lead.

For circulation across the network and partners. Figures reflect the latest published data at the date of this brief.